

In the Studio

Painting, Photography, and Other Realities

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from: "Dear Painter,"
paint me...
Painting the Figure
since late Picabia
- Centre Pompidou
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Rembrandt's remarkably small painting *An Artist in His Studio* was produced around 1628. It is a self-portrait full of contradictions and allusions that to this day have not been properly clarified or considered. The 22-year-old painter's pose is restrained, but self-confident. He is dressed in the latest fashion (hat, ruff) and in a somewhat outdated, but magnificent overcoat in his pitifully poor Leiden home with its crumbling masonry and plaster. Across from the painter, on this miniature painted on wood which today hangs in Boston, is an easel with a panel that appears oversized. Both elements have merged to form a single object that is seen from the back, ominously jutting into the foreground. In this anamorphic distortion, the distance between the subject and object seems to be deliberately emphasized. The painter is holding a single brush in his right hand, and a bunch of brushes in the left along with a palette and mahlstick. Additional utensils of the craft, among them tools to produce paint, are behind him on the wall, on a tree stump and on a table.

So far so good. In terms of interpretation, the consensus is that this piece is an examination of theories about painting at the time. Ernst van de Wetering suggested that the painter is not depicting himself while working on a painting, but before starting to work. Painting, according to contemporary *concetti*, is based on *idea*, *fortuna* (chance), or *usus* (exercise). Rembrandt's studio painting refers to the first term, the "contemplative formation of an idea in the mind." (Simon Schama, *Rembrandt's Eyes*, 1999)

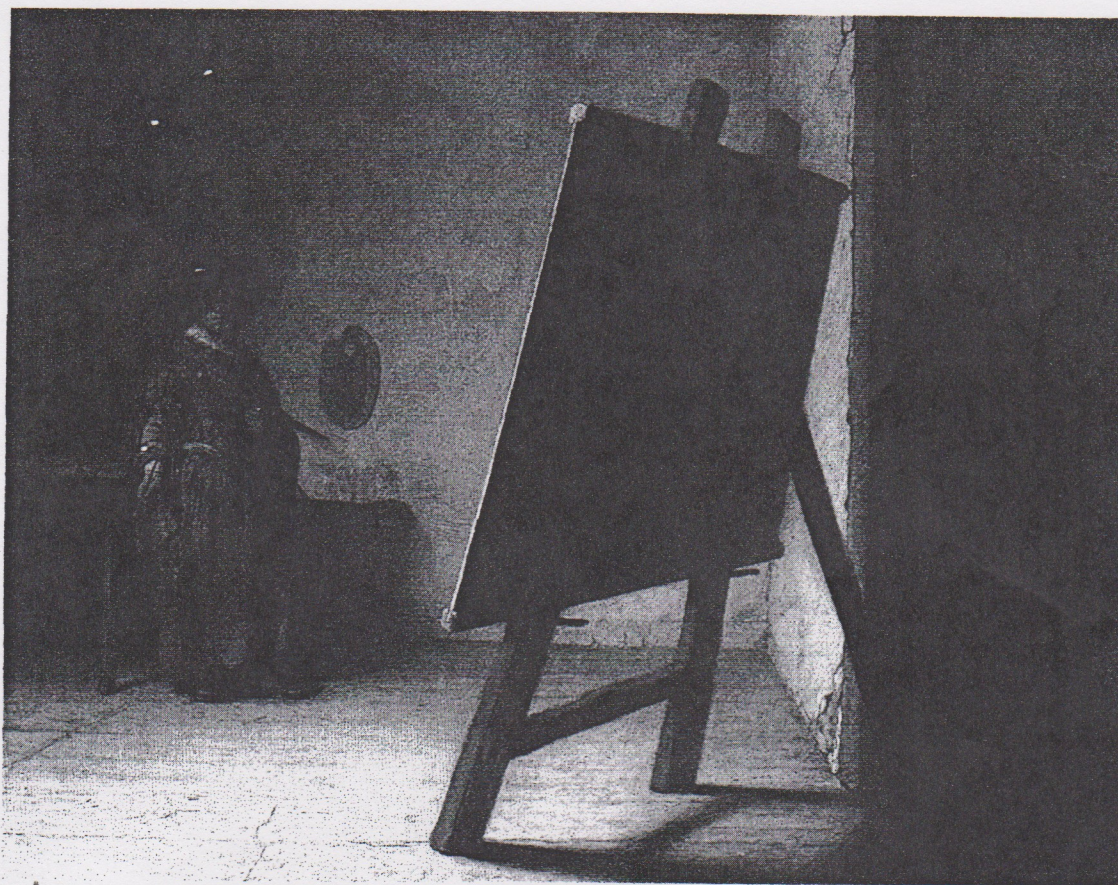
But such an interpretation can only work if you assume that the vague gaze of the painter is focused on the canvas. He could also be looking at the viewer. This frustrating staring phenomenon has to do with the way Rembrandt painted the eyes. While contemporary painters, as well as Rembrandt in most of his other works, can best demonstrate their skill by a precise rendering of eyes, the eyes in this studio painting appear like

shadowy "black holes—hollow cavities behind which something is being created, not destroyed. Behind these holes, deep in the depths of the imagination, is where the real action is, the cogs and wheels; the mental machinery is whirling and turning, like the subtly interlocking parts of a chronometer. An idea is coming into being." (Simon Schama)

Now there are three versions of the gaze: one looking at the painting, one turned inward, one focused on the viewer. The first two, as we saw above, can be connected with the *idea*; the third, looking at the viewer, does not fit into the first interpretation. And yet it is worth our attention. It draws us into the painting and at the same time underscores the loneliness of the artist. Like the overcoat, there is something demonstrative, egomaniac, about him. Look, it's me! I stand before you as a prince in my miserable home. I am rich because I am the creator. This miniature you are standing before is the painting I created, and in this painting I am standing in front of a painting I have not yet painted, but it stands for all of the paintings I could paint. I am great in my smallness; my miniature proves my capacity to expand.

It is significant that this self-portrait in the studio is above all filled with emptiness, or void. Rembrandt demonstrates that he can master texture as well as an unmarked surface, the frills of clothing as well as the plaster in the wall, the soft as well as the hard and, of course, light in its subtly illuminating or broken effects.

The conspicuously white edge of the panel painting on the easel separates the painting diagonally into two halves. On the left is emptiness, light, and self-demonstration, on the right hard reality and shadows, with the door indicating a way out. It is the dilapidated door out to the world, and the artist will open it when the painting is finished. The door, oversized for this reason, leads to the sphere from which the idea comes. It is a symbol formed out of reality.



Rembrandt van Rijn
Schilder in zijn Atelier, c.1627-28
 ["An Artist in His Studio"]
 Oil on wood, 24,8 x 31,7 cm
 Museum of Fine Arts, Boston

Our miniature is a fundamental work about the art of painting and is singular in the history of studio paintings. As art about art, the emptiness of the room and the back of the painting refer to the problems of Modernism. As a painting about painting, it unites technique and skill with idea in a mutually dependent condition. As a painting of eyes, it focuses attention on two points. As realism, it demonstrates the constructive ability of this art caught as it is between the objectivity of representation and the abstractions of surface and detail.

In Europe, this miniature was last shown at the exhibition *Der junge Rembrandt: Rätsel um seine Anfänge* ('The Young Rembrandt: Mysteries of His Early Years') in Kassel and Amsterdam. This fine exhibition demonstrated the impossibility of identifying the genesis of the paint-

er's works. Instead it became clear that even at the beginning of his career Rembrandt mastered various styles and manners of painting which he experimented with simultaneously rather than consecutively. The painter's "rough style", for example, occurs in his early work alongside detailed painting, and in some instances both can be found in a single painting. The self-reflective quality which defines Rembrandt's entire oeuvre, expressed in the endless physiognomic explorations of his own face and the theatricalization of the self through personal loves, passions, and sufferings, is also characteristic of his religious work and public commissions. This quality finds its beginning in this miniature.

This is why this painting plays a key role in determining where painting is today. It proves that:

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- it is necessary and sensible for painters to be aware of the concepts of their time, something we could refer to today as visual or media theory. This knowledge doesn't need to be spread too thickly in their work, but it must be present;
- realism has always been on the edge of abstraction (see, for example, the eyes or the delicate little area of unplastered wall near the floor in the right-hand of the room);
- conversely, a concept or an idea doesn't necessarily lead to abstraction, but can instead be expressed in elements of reality;
- the self-referential is not an invention of Modernism. It has been a condition of painting since the Renaissance, and in this painting it is passed on to Modernism as a conclusion;
- a painting is always an object, as demonstrated all too obviously in the miniature with the panel on the easel. Rembrandt's evocation of the edge of the painting is an astute contribution to this discussion of Modernism;
- a painting can contain several paintings, in this case a self-portrait, another painting, and an almost empty interior. These paintings do not have to correspond with each other, but can each lead an independent life. This triples the possibilities of interpretation;
- a painting need not show what we expect to see. It could, like the back of the painting seen here, be a negation. This also appears in the work, *Back of a Painting*, (ca. 1660-75) by Cornelis Norbertus Gijsbrecht, but this belongs to the baffling realm of *trompe l'oeil* rather than to direct artistic self-portrayal;
- painting as understood by Aby Warburg creates a "space for symbolic thinking" and thus results in a conscious distance between the painter and the painting and the viewer and the painting.

If, as recent Rembrandt research establishes, it poses a problem to constrict the oeuvre of an individual artist to the traditional categories of early and late works, it would be even less sufficient to adhere to an art history that consists of a sequence of styles. Since such an art history ultimately has to culminate in the abstraction of Modernism, art would become a banal accomplice of a Hegelian monumentalism, a notion that was rejected early on by Alois Riegl, Aby Warburg, Carl Einstein, and more recently Otto Stelzer, Werner Hofmann, Victor I. Stoichita and others. The essential moments of art history are always present in museums. It is necessary, therefore, to connect and combine individual histories in various innovative ways in order to reflect their distinct historic dimensions. Alongside archival research, one of the new tasks of aesthetics is to link material with a view to creating "space for symbolic thinking."

It becomes clear that, among other media, photography has tried since the beginning to imitate the pictorial presence of painting (*tableaux vivants*, pictorialism). However there is a common misconception that photography forced painting into abstraction because the camera was better equipped to represent reality. Such views need to be revised, especially since photography produced

photograms which were an attempt to explore the cryptic language of abstraction at approximately the same time as painting.

In fact, as witnessed by the Rembrandt example, painting has always reflected its inherent challenge to be able to depict reality. Earlier artists such as Piero della Francesca, Michelangelo, Hieronymus Bosch, and Pontormo seem for example "less realistic" from today's perspective, while artists like El Greco, Diego Velázquez and Francisco Goya seem more powerful, simply because in their theoretical, ideological, and technical determination, they show that taking refuge in the unconditional abstraction inherent in their works was not an option.

From this perspective, a revision of the history of Modernism should rehabilitate painting's ability to examine these different realities. Just as Gustave Courbet and Adolph Menzel at the beginning of the photographic era reflected their path to reality by referencing this new medium in their paintings, our task today is to reevaluate the works of painters like Otto Dix, Max Beckmann, Salvador Dalí, Francis Picabia, Giorgio de Chirico, Charles Demuth, Karl Hofer, René Magritte, Richard Oelze, Edward Hopper, Anton Räderscheidt, Pierre Roy, Stuart Davis, and Christian Schad. Abstraction, then, no longer appears to be a compromise, but a path (an escape route?) which—among other things—has been taken in reaction to photography.

With the birth of abstraction, art history came to a standstill because abstract paintings required commentary—as proposed by Arnold Gehlen. To this day, art history is still confronted with the theories postulated by Clement Greenberg, whose historic interest lies only in his "modernist" terminology (kitsch, unity, identity, taste), since the world of images has long since changed. Compared to the current obsession with images, the abstractionists who used to be so revolutionary suddenly appear helplessly lost in their own colorful arbitrariness. They have mutated into the props of a poster culture for teenage girls' bedrooms, and museum shops do what they can to uphold this embarrassing status quo. The only reverence that can still be detected is in the academic world of art historians, where the number of masters or doctoral theses on artists like Paul Klee is in no way declining. Another alternative is for art history to turn its attention to photography and film and sell "new media" as a radical reorientation of the field. This trend has engendered an art that seems to be made for contemporary art historians—work by the likes of Cindy Sherman, Bill Viola, Peter Greenaway, James Turrell, Joseph Beuys, and Jenny Holzer. The only painter in this genre is Gerhard Richter, but he is perfectly suited for reflection on issues of new media since he once said that anyone who paints is on the wrong boat. But enough of this polemic digression. Let's get back to the topic.

The fact that the death of painting has been proclaimed every ten years since the beginning of photography is

definitely a sign of tremendous uncertainty. After all, in the course of its existence, painting has experimented so much with its boundaries and with the transcendence of its possibilities that its failure has always been inherent. As suggested earlier, this has been the case at least since the Renaissance. We need only to think of the profound melancholy in the poems of Michelangelo and recurring in the letters of van Gogh or of the all-embracing love of experimentation espoused by artists like Leonardo and later Picabia. Samuel Beckett gets to the heart of the matter in his commentary *Peintres de l'empêchement* (1948): "What remains to be represented are the conditions of withdrawal ... The thing to paint is what prevents one from painting." But this prevention is also a liberty derived from the limitless possibilities of the medium. This is why the history of painting will not allow for naïveté anymore, unless you want to be a naïve painter. Painting, then, is connected with a philosophy that for good reason propagates its own continuation. The point is to constantly redefine oneself. And this brings us back to *idea, fortuna, and usus*.

In the same piece, Beckett writes: "What renews painting is first of all that there are always more things to paint ..." What remains unclear in this instance is whether the author was referring to the development of new media. Since Courbet, it's a fact that photography

has expanded, strengthened its tasks, representational possibilities and subjects, in relation to the experience of reality. Painting has always been an artistic reflection on other works (Renaissance refers to Antiquity, Classicism to the Renaissance, Modernism to Mannerism, etc.), and since the inception of photography and film the kingdom of images has been enriched to no end. This was anticipated as early as 1907 by Alfred Lichtwark, for many years the director of the Hamburg Kunsthalle, who spoke of a revival of painting as a result of photography.

Painting has at its disposal not only the works of its past, but also the arsenal of all images and all realities. Abstraction negated these possibilities through romantic notions about elevating the inner life of the artist to an ersatz religion.

Painting dwells in an intermediary state of theory, craft, visual interpretation, and invention. Painting is an art of the external world and as such it is a political demonstration of the potential of realities and their images. It does not shy away from exposing silliness, banality, stupidity, sexism, and other repulsive qualities as part of these realities and images. As a practice of seeing bound to the body, it roughens the smoothness of the reality conveyed by the media and leads it back into the realm of the idea and hence the other reality of mental space.

(translated from the German by Susan Schwartz)